

PHAR6202: Advanced Clinical Decision Making and Professional Prescribing

Callaghan, Gosford
Semester 2 - 2026



THE UNIVERSITY OF
NEWCASTLE
AUSTRALIA

OVERVIEW

Course Description

Advanced Clinical Decision Making and Professional Prescribing is the second of two courses designed to prepare students for safe, effective, and collaborative prescribing practice. Building on the foundational knowledge and skills developed in Foundations of Professional Prescribing and Patient-Centred Care, this course provides students with opportunities to apply and demonstrate prescribing competence in a range of clinical scenarios. Students will undertake structured, patient-centred consultations, applying advanced clinical reasoning to develop and implement evidence-based management plans. The course emphasises safe and appropriate prescribing, accurate documentation, effective communication, and collaboration with patients, carers, and other healthcare providers to ensure continuity of care. Students will also develop and demonstrate skills in monitoring therapeutic outcomes, managing adverse effects, and adjusting treatment plans where necessary. Reflective practice, prescribing governance, and a commitment to ongoing quality improvement will be central to developing readiness for practice as a prescriber.

Requisites

Program Enrolment Rule:
Available to students in the following program(s):
Graduate Certificate in Pharmacist Prescribing and Advanced Practice [50097]

Assumed Knowledge

Some skills in health assessment and clinical decision making. Ability to justify clinical decision making. Ability to access and evaluate information from a variety of sources.

Contact Hours

Callaghan and Gosford

Integrated Learning Session* (Work Integrated Learning)

Face to face and Online

30 hours per Semester

Work Integrated Learning (ILS) with a Designated Prescribing Practitioner (DPP)

Online Activity

4 hours per week for 12 weeks, starting Week 1

Practical*

Face to Face On Campus

2 x 7.5 hours per week for 2 weeks, Weeks 5, 10 Callaghan

2 x 7.5 hours per week for 2 weeks, Weeks 5, 10 Gosford

Face-to-face intensives to practice clinical skills relating to diagnosis and prescribing

Attendance at intensives is compulsory to pass this course.

Unit Weighting

10

COURSE OUTLINE

www.newcastle.edu.au

CRICOS Provider 00109J

Workload	Students are required to spend on average 120-140 hours of effort (contact and non-contact) including assessments per 10-unit course.
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CONTACTS

Course Coordinator	Callaghan, Gosford Alison Hooper Alison.Hooper@newcastle.edu.au Consultation: By email A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin Sarah.DineenGriffin@newcastle.edu.au Consultation: By email
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Teaching Staff	Other teaching staff will be advised on the course Canvas site.
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School Office	School of Biomedical Sciences and Pharmacy MS607 Medical Sciences Building, Callaghan Biomedsci-Admin@newcastle.edu.au 02 49212058 or 49212008 8:30am – 5:00pm (Mon – Fri)
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SYLLABUS

Course Content	1. Integrating Legal, Ethical and Clinical Reasoning in Prescribing Practice 2. Advanced Patient Consultations and Clinical Assessment 3. Culturally Responsive Prescribing in Diverse Populations 4. Technology Enhanced and Evidence-Based Prescribing 5. Prescribing Documentation, Governance and Monitoring 6. Interprofessional Collaboration and Referral in Prescribing 7. Prescribing Leadership and Accountability 8. Prescribing Safety, Reflection and Professional Development
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Course Learning Outcomes	On successful completion of this course, students will be able to: 1. Integrate legal, ethical, clinical and cultural considerations into safe, accountable prescribing decisions across a range of real or simulated clinical settings. 2. Achieve effective patient-centred care by undertaking comprehensive, structured patient consultations and demonstrating advanced communication, clinical assessment, and shared-decision making skills in authentic scenarios. 3. Formulate and implement safe, evidence-informed prescribing decisions and management plans for patients with varying levels of complexity. 4. Accurately document prescribing decisions, monitoring strategies, and interprofessional communications in line with legal and professional standards. 5. Work collaboratively within interprofessional teams to support safe, coordinated, and person-centred prescribing and care. 6. Critically evaluate prescribing practice, identify personal learning needs, and provide leadership to improve the safety and quality of prescribing.
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Course Materials	Students are strongly encouraged to purchase the following equipment: • A penlight torch • A Littmann Classic III stethoscope • An otoscope
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Texts and material will be available online; links will be provided via Canvas_and/or access via the library <http://www.newcastle.edu.au/service/library/>

COMPULSORY REQUIREMENTS

In order to pass this course, each student must complete ALL of the following compulsory requirements:

Contact Hour Requirements:

- **Integrated Learning Session (Work Integrated Learning):** Compulsory attendance and satisfactory participation are required. Satisfactory participation will be determined through sign-off by the student's Designated Prescribing Practitioner (DPP).
- **Practical Intensives:** Compulsory attendance and satisfactory participation are required for all face-to-face intensive sessions.

Course Assessment Requirements:

- Assessment 1 – Prescribing Portfolio and Workplace Based Assessments: Submit assessment item – Must submit this assessment to pass the Course.
- Assessment 2 – Reflection on the use of Generative Artificial Intelligence in Clinical Documentation: Submit assessment item – Must submit this assessment to pass the Course.
- Assessment 3 – Multi-station OSCE: Pass requirement – Must pass this assessment item to pass the course.

Compulsory Placement and WHS Requirements:

- NSW Health Verification Requirements – Mandatory NSW Health Verification Requirements must be met for student's attending a NSW Health facility for Work Integrated Learning.

SCHEDULE

Date	Day	Time	Location	Topic	Lecturer
Week 1 17 Aug					
Thinking Ethically: Frameworks, Autonomy and Accountability				Ethical principles in prescribing; applying ethical frameworks to independent and supplementary prescribing; ethical decision-making frameworks; professional autonomy and accountability; paternalism, commercialism and loyalty, privacy and confidentiality.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
				Tutorial 1: Tuesday 18 August 2026 6:30pm-7:30pm	
Week 2 24 Aug					
Practising Ethically: Communication, Boundaries and Safe Prescribing				Patient autonomy and relational prescribing; therapeutic relationships; professional boundaries for pharmacist prescribers; communication and ethics; ethical and professional tensions in practice; ethical challenges in prescribing, including prescribing for family members, prescribing under time pressure and off-label use; medico-legal risks and low-value care.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
				No tutorial this week	
Week 3 31 Aug					
Communication Foundations for Pharmacist Prescribers				Foundations of effective communication; verbal, non-verbal and written communication; communication blocks; mindful communication in clinical practice; communication styles; building rapport in professional consultations; avoiding common questioning pitfalls; health psychology for prescriber communication; adapting communication to support patients with hearing or vision impairment.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
				Tutorial 2: Tuesday 1 September 2026 6:30pm-7:30pm	
Week 4 7 Sep					
Advanced Communication in Complex Prescribing Contexts				Emotional intelligence in prescribing practice; communicating with patients from diverse backgrounds; cultural competence, humility and safety; working with culturally and linguistically diverse patients; interpreter use; shared decision-making with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people; managing patient expectations; managing conflict and difficult scenarios; communicating with patients and other health professionals following a prescribing or medication error.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
				No tutorial this week	

Week 5 14 Sep		
Clinical Reasoning and Decision-Making	INTENSIVE LABS 2 days – Callaghan and Gosford	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
	Foundations of clinical reasoning; pharmacist prescriber skill set; clinical reasoning cycle; models of reasoning; illness scripts and pattern recognition; bias, confidence and uncertainty in prescribing; diagnostic frameworks; differential diagnosis; testing and treatment thresholds; communicating clinical reasoning using summary statements and semantic qualifiers; self-reflection on clinical reasoning; shared decision-making in prescribing; applying culturally safe and person-centred approaches to clinical assessment and prescribing, including consideration of the needs and priorities of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples.	
	Tutorial 3: Wednesday 16 September 2026 6:30pm-7:30pm	
Week 6 21 Sep		
Error, Uncertainty and Patient Safety	Errors, human factors and patient safety; diagnostic and prescribing errors; the relationship between diagnostic and prescribing errors; test interpretation, including sensitivity, specificity, predictive value and pre-test probability; Bayesian reasoning and likelihood ratios; strategies to reduce diagnostic error; managing uncertainty in prescribing; safety-netting; preventing cognitive errors in healthcare.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
	No tutorial this week	
Recess Break 28 September – 2 October		
Week 7 5 Oct		
Interprofessional Communication and Collaboration	Foundations of interprofessional collaborative practice; patient-centred care within the healthcare team; interprofessional collaboration and patient safety; communication challenges in interprofessional teams; providing feedback and negotiating in teams; managing conflict and using assertive communication; personality and communication in interprofessional teams; team communication scenarios; responding when clinical decisions are challenged; reflective practice using the Gibbs Reflective Cycle.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
	No tutorial this week	
Week 8 12 Oct		
When Things Go Wrong...	Understanding why errors occur in complex healthcare systems; person-centred and systems-based approaches to error; Swiss cheese model; Yorkshire Contributory Factors Framework; approaches to analysing errors; Root Cause Analysis; Significant Event Analysis; human factors analysis; sensemaking conversations; emotional and psychological impact of errors; responding constructively after errors and near misses; learning from incidents to improve patient safety and prescribing practice.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
Tutorial 4: Tuesday 13 October 2026 6:30pm-7:30pm		
Week 9 19 Oct		
Advanced Physical Assessment I	Role of physical assessment in pharmacist prescribing; integrating history-taking, clinical examination and diagnostic reasoning; using physical assessment findings to rule in and rule out differential diagnoses; systematic examination techniques including inspection, palpation, percussion and auscultation; recognising red flags and signs of clinical deterioration; applying structured assessment approaches to common presentations, including respiratory, cardiovascular, gastrointestinal and ENT symptoms; interpreting findings in the context of the person's presenting complaint, medical history and scope of prescribing practice.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
	No tutorial this week	
Week 10 26 Oct		
Advanced Physical Assessment II	INTENSIVE LABS 2 days – Callaghan and Gosford	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
	Advanced application of physical assessment and clinical investigation in prescribing practice; interpreting	

	laboratory tests and pathology results to support diagnosis, therapeutic decision-making, monitoring and follow-up; integrating physical examination findings with laboratory results, patient-reported symptoms and clinical history; using clinical reasoning principles including Occam's razor, where the simplest explanation may be most likely, and Hickam's dictum, recognising that patients may have multiple concurrent conditions; applying assessment findings to refine differential diagnoses, identify uncertainty, determine when to treat, monitor or refer, and document clinical reasoning clearly.	
Tutorial 5: Tuesday 27 October 2026 6:30pm-7:30pm		
Week 11 2 Nov		
Governance and Leadership	Governance structures that support safe and accountable pharmacist prescribing; clinical governance, risk management, quality improvement and professional accountability; leadership responsibilities in prescribing practice; creating safe systems for escalation, documentation, audit and review; contributing to a culture of safety, reflective practice and continuous improvement; leading change in pharmacy practice while working within professional, legal and organisational frameworks; supporting interprofessional collaboration, service evaluation and prescribing quality.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
	No tutorial this week	
Week 12 9 Nov		
Technology in Prescribing: AI, Decision Support Systems and Wearables	Role of technology in contemporary prescribing practice; electronic prescribing, clinical decision support systems, digital health records and prescribing software; opportunities and risks associated with artificial intelligence in clinical decision-making; safe and ethical use of digital tools, including privacy, consent, transparency, accountability and bias; use of wearable technologies and patient-generated health data to support monitoring, follow-up and person-centred care; interpreting digital data within clinical context; recognising limitations of technology and maintaining professional judgement in prescribing decisions.	Alison Hooper A/Prof Sarah Dineen-Griffin
	Tutorial 6: Tuesday 10 November 2026 6:30pm-7:30pm	

INTENSIVE LABS 2 days – Callaghan cohort

Week 5

Sat	8:30 – 16:00	TBC	19-Sep
Sun	8:30 – 16:00	TBC	20-Sep

Week 10

Sat	8:30 – 16:00	TBC	31-Oct
Sun	8:30 – 16:00	TBC	1-Nov

INTENSIVE LABS 2 days – Gosford cohort

Week 5

Thu	8:30 – 16:00	GO93940	17-Sep
Fri	8:30 – 12:00	GO93856	18-Sep
Fri	12:00 – 16:00	GO93857	18-Sep

Week 10

Thu	8:30 – 16:00	GO93940	29-Oct
Fri	8:30 – 16:00	GO93940	30-Oct

ASSESSMENTS

This course has 3 assessments. Each assessment is described in more detail in the sections below.

	Assessment Name	Due Date	Involvement	Weighting	Learning Outcomes
1	Prescribing Portfolio and Workplace Based Assessments*	Friday 13 November 2026 11:59pm (Week 12)	Individual	30%	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6
2	Reflection on the use of Generative Artificial Intelligence in Clinical Documentation*	Friday 9 October 2026 11:59pm (Week 7)	Individual	20%	1, 4, 6
3	Multi-station OSCE*	In formal examination period at a date/time to be advised	Individual	50%	1, 2, 3, 4, 5

* This assessment has a compulsory requirement.

Late Submissions

The mark for an assessment item submitted after the designated time on the due date, without an approved extension of time, will be reduced by up to 10% of the possible maximum mark for that assessment item for each day or part day that the assessment item is late. Note: this applies equally to week and weekend days.

Assessment 1 - Prescribing Portfolio and Workplace Based Assessments

Assessment Type Description

Log / Workbook and Practical Demonstration

This assessment comprises a Prescribing Portfolio and a series of Workplace-Based Assessments (WBAs) designed to evaluate development and application of prescribing knowledge and skills in clinical practice.

The Prescribing Portfolio will provide evidence of learning and professional development throughout the course and may include clinical case reflections, prescribing activities, documentation of clinical experiences, self-assessment, and records of feedback received from supervisors and other health professionals. Students will be required to reflect on culturally safe prescribing practice and demonstrate consideration of cultural, social and health system factors that influence prescribing decisions, including care provided to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples and other priority populations.

The WBAs will consist of various clinical tasks undertaken in practice settings to assess competence in key areas of prescribing practice. These assessments may include patient history taking, physical examination, diagnostic planning, clinical reasoning, development of management plans, safe and appropriate prescribing, interprofessional communication, clinical documentation, and patient-centred care, within a pharmacists' scope of practice. WBAs may also assess culturally responsive communication, shared decision-making and culturally safe prescribing in authentic clinical settings.

Together, the portfolio and WBAs are intended to demonstrate readiness for safe, effective, and evidence-based prescribing practice. Further details will be provided during the Semester.

Weighting

30%

Compulsory Requirements

Submit assessment item - Must submit this assessment to pass the Course.

Due Date

Friday 13 November 2026 11:59pm (Week 12)

Submission Method

Completed online via Canvas

Assessment Criteria

Full assessment criteria are available on the course Canvas site.

Return Method

Feedback will be provided.

Feedback Provided

Online / email

Opportunity to Reattempt

Students will not be given the opportunity to reattempt this assessment.

Use of AI Tools

AI tools are not permitted to be used for this assessment.

Assessment 2 - Reflection on the use of Gen AI in Clinical Documentation

Assessment Type	Audio-visual presentation and written reflection
Description	The assessment consists of a 12-minute pre-recorded video presentation of a simulated patient consultation. Students are required to document their own clinical notes from the consultation and compare these with notes produced by an approved Gen AI software. Further details will be provided during the Semester.
Weighting	20%
Compulsory Requirements	Submit assessment item - Must submit this assessment to pass the Course.
Due Date	Friday 9 October 2026 11:59pm (Week 7)
Submission Method	Completed online via Canvas
Assessment Criteria	Full assessment criteria are available on the course Canvas site.
Return Method	Not returned
Feedback Provided	Online / email
Opportunity to Reattempt	Students will not be given the opportunity to reattempt this assessment.
Use of AI Tools	Students are required to use an approved generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) tool as part of this assessment. The assessment requires students to critically evaluate AI-generated clinical documentation by comparing it with documentation they have produced themselves. AI may only be used for the purposes specified in the assessment instructions. Students remain responsible for all submitted work and must demonstrate their own clinical reasoning, professional judgement, and critical analysis. Any use of AI outside the permitted scope may constitute a breach of the University's Academic Integrity and Ethical Academic Conduct Policy.

Assessment 3 - Multi-station OSCE

Assessment Type	Formal examination
Description	The OSCE will include several stations, intended to cover topic areas relevant to pharmacist prescribing, including but not limited to acute presentations and chronic/complex cases. Each station will integrate basic sciences with clinical practice and assess competencies such as history taking, examination, interpretation of investigation, clinical reasoning, diagnosis, management, communication, and person-centered care. OSCE stations may also assess culturally safe communication, shared decision-making and prescribing with people from diverse backgrounds, including Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples.
Weighting	50%
Standard Setting	The cut-score for OSCE examinations is determined using a borderline regression method.
Compulsory Requirements	Pass requirement - Must pass this assessment item to pass the course.
Due Date	In formal examination period. Please see the relevant guide/s or schedule on Canvas.
Submission Method	On campus
Assessment Criteria	Full assessment criteria are available on the course Canvas site
Return Method	Not applicable.
Feedback Provided	Feedback will be provided on request.
Opportunity to Reattempt	Students who do not achieve a passing grade in this assessment, but who meet the other course requirements will be offered an opportunity to reattempt this assessment. Students who undertake a supplementary examination and satisfactorily pass the assessment and pass the course overall will be awarded a maximum mark of 50 for the course. Those who do not pass the supplementary examination will be awarded a CF grade, irrespective of their final numeric mark.
Use of AI Tools	AI tools are not permitted for use during this assessment.

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Grading Scheme

This course is graded as follows:

Range of Marks	Grade	Description
85-100	High Distinction (HD)	Outstanding standard indicating comprehensive knowledge and understanding of the relevant materials; demonstration of an outstanding level of academic achievement; mastery of skills*; and achievement of all assessment objectives.
75-84	Distinction (D)	Excellent standard indicating a very high level of knowledge and understanding of the relevant materials; demonstration of a very high level of academic ability; sound development of skills*; and achievement of all assessment objectives.
65-74	Credit (C)	Good standard indicating a high level of knowledge and understanding of the relevant materials; demonstration of a high level of academic achievement; reasonable development of skills*; and achievement of all learning outcomes.
50-64	Pass (P)	Satisfactory standard indicating an adequate knowledge and understanding of the relevant materials; demonstration of an adequate level of academic achievement; satisfactory development of skills*; and achievement of all learning outcomes.
0-49	Fail (FF)	Failure to satisfactorily achieve learning outcomes. If all compulsory course components are not completed the mark will be zero. A fail grade may also be awarded following disciplinary action.

*Skills are those identified for the purposes of assessment task(s).

Communication Methods

Communication methods used in this course include:

- **Canvas Course Site:** Students will receive communications via announcements on the Canvas course site.
- **Email:** Students will receive communications via their student email account.

Course Evaluation

Each year feedback is sought from students and other stakeholders about the courses offered in the University for the purposes of identifying areas of excellence and potential improvement.

Learning Analytics

The University uses an evidence-based approach to enhancing student learning and delivering support. Our careful analysis of data through learning analytics informs decision making processes related to student learning, academic outcomes, and support services. Learning analytics may be used to identify targeted individual opportunities for additional support services or interventions.

Interviews on Assessment Items

An Interview may be conducted on any assessment item in this course, in accordance with the [Interview on Assessment Items Procedure](#). The purpose of the interview is to verify the author of the material submitted in response to the assessment task and provide a quality assurance measure. In the event the Course Coordinator is not satisfied that a student's oral responses are consistent with the work originally submitted, the matter will be referred to the Student Academic Conduct Officer, who will take appropriate action under the [Student Conduct Rule](#).

Academic Integrity and Ethical Academic Conduct Policy

All students are required to meet the academic integrity standards of the University. These standards reinforce the importance of integrity and honesty in an academic environment. Academic Integrity policies apply to all students of the University in all modes of study and in all locations. Please refer to the [Academic Integrity and Ethical Academic Conduct Policy](#)

Adverse Circumstances

The University acknowledges the right of students to seek consideration for the impact of allowable adverse circumstances that may affect their performance in assessment item(s). Applications for special consideration due to adverse circumstances will be made using the online Adverse Circumstances system where:

1. the assessment item is a major assessment item; or
2. the assessment item is a minor assessment item and the Course Co-ordinator has specified in the Course Outline that students may apply the online Adverse Circumstances system;
3. you are requesting a change of placement; or
4. the course has a compulsory attendance requirement.

Before applying you must refer to the [Adverse Circumstance Affecting Assessment Items Procedure](#).

Use of generative artificial intelligence in course assessments

It is critical that any work submitted for assessment is your own original work. Before using generative AI tools (such as ChatGPT, Perplexity, Microsoft Copilot, etc) in any assessable work you must ensure that such use is in line with the requirements for the course and expectations of your Course Coordinator. Misuse of AI tools may be considered a breach of the [University's Student Conduct Rule](#) and could result in disciplinary action.

Artificial Intelligence detection software may be used to review any work you submit. If you have used AI in any way other than has been expressly permitted by your course coordinator, you may be engaging in academic misconduct and be subject to penalties.

For information, refer to:

- [Generative AI Tools](#)
- [Academic Integrity](#)

Important Policy Information

The Help button in the Canvas Navigation menu contains helpful information for using the Learning Management System. Students should familiarise themselves with the policies and procedures at <https://www.newcastle.edu.au/current-students/respect-at-uni/policies-and-procedures> that support a safe and respectful environment at the University

This course outline was approved by the Head of School. No alteration of this course outline is permitted without Head of School approval. If a change is approved, students will be notified and an amended course outline will be provided in the same manner as the original.

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